The same year, the company also bought a 74 per cent stake for an undisclosed amount in the ‘Hyderabad-based HBL Elta Avionics’, its first acquisition in defence. The remaining 26 per cent was ‘held by its foreign partner ELTA Systems, a unit of Israel Aerospace Industries’.

In 2011, TASL’s wholly owned subsidiary Nova Integrated Systems commenced its plan to establish an ‘integrated aerospace complex [to] undertake high end precision electronics manufacturing, assembly and integration of airborne vehicles’.

In 2012, the company ‘formed a strategic alliance’ with US-based ITT Exelis to ‘support Generation (Gen) 3 night vision requirements in India’. The same year, it also ‘acquired a majority stake’ in the Bangalore-based Aurora Integrated Systems Limited, an organization that focused on ‘systems that encompass short range small unmanned aerial vehicle system to long range tactical systems, rapidly deployable aerostat systems, and technologies in inertial navigation’. By then, TASL had also established ‘more than half a million square feet of manufacturing facilities’ in Bangalore, Hyderabad and New Delhi, and employed ‘around 1,000 personnel’.

## Abiding Faith in the Group

The initial orders that came to TASL were on account of Ratan, Singh recalls. Ratan was so well connected and respected across the globe that when he declared that the defence company had the capability to undertake a project, virtually no one questioned his claim. Singh also mentions that three major programmes were transferred to TASL from single sources, or the sole manufacturers of parts, from some of the most advanced nations—the US, Japan and South Korea. It was a testimony to the exacting standards of military precision that TASL was able to deliver.

The deal for manufacturing the empennage (tail assembly) of the Lockheed Martin C-130J Super Hercules came about after Ratan personally spoke to Ralph D. Heath, former executive vice president of aeronautics at Boeing. Similarly, the Sikorsky S-92 project was secured after Ratan’s intervention with Louis R. Chênevert, then chairman and CEO of United Technologies, the former owners of Sikorsky. And when one US importer insisted on TASL signing an unlimited liability contract, Ratan worked the phone to dial an American supplier, whose board he had been on for some